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ARTICLE

The Cyberattack Crisis: The Coming Battle For Control Of The Internet



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 23, 2026

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Imagine waking up tomorrow morning to discover that your bank's website is inaccessible. Your credit card no longer works. Gas stations cannot process payments. Grocery stores are accepting cash only, while others have closed entirely because their computerized systems are down.

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Now imagine that the problem isn't limited to your community or even your country. Major financial institutions around the world are experiencing similar disruptions, and nobody knows how long they will last.

For most Americans, such a scenario sounds like something out of a Hollywood disaster movie. But for the cybersecurity professionals who spend their days defending the digital infrastructure upon which modern civilization depends, the threat is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore.

And the latest wave of cyberattacks raises an unsettling question: Could the growing vulnerability of our digital world eventually create the conditions for a global financial system in which buying and selling are tightly controlled?

For students of Bible prophecy, that question should sound remarkably familiar.



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At Prophecy News Watch, we have experienced this digital battlefield firsthand.

During October alone, our website has faced more than 200,000 malicious requests and attempted attacks. Most of our readers never know anything is happening. They visit the website, read the news, and continue with their day, unaware of the constant activity taking place behind the scenes.

Our security systems intercept and block most of these threats. But the experience provides a sobering glimpse into a world that the average internet user rarely sees.

Every day, automated programs probe websites for weaknesses. Hackers search for vulnerable software, outdated security systems, exposed databases, and overlooked entry points. Some attacks are relatively unsophisticated. Others are designed to exploit weaknesses that even experienced programmers may not know exist.

And the attackers never need to sleep.

Now multiply that activity across millions of websites, including banks, hospitals, electrical utilities, transportation networks, government agencies, and the companies responsible for processing financial transactions.

The internet may appear to be functioning normally, but beneath the surface, an enormous struggle is underway to keep it secure.

A Dangerous Discovery Beneath The Internet

The latest alarm involves PHP, a programming language used by roughly 70 percent of websites whose server-side programming language can be identified.

PHP helps power everything from ordinary blogs and online stores to major publishing platforms and business applications. Many organizations depend upon it without their customers ever knowing it exists.

On October 21, researchers disclosed two critical vulnerabilities, collectively known as PHP2Shell, that could allow attackers to execute malicious code on vulnerable servers without first logging in.

Even more disturbing, Amazon's security researchers detected an attempt to exploit these vulnerabilities on October 17, four days before they were publicly disclosed. That raises the troubling possibility that attackers were already targeting weaknesses before the wider cybersecurity community even knew they existed.

Cloudflare subsequently reported millions of attempts to exploit the flaws as website operators raced to install emergency security updates.

Consider the implications. A vulnerability in a single company's software might threaten thousands of customers. But a serious weakness in technology used throughout the internet potentially exposes an enormous number of unrelated organizations.

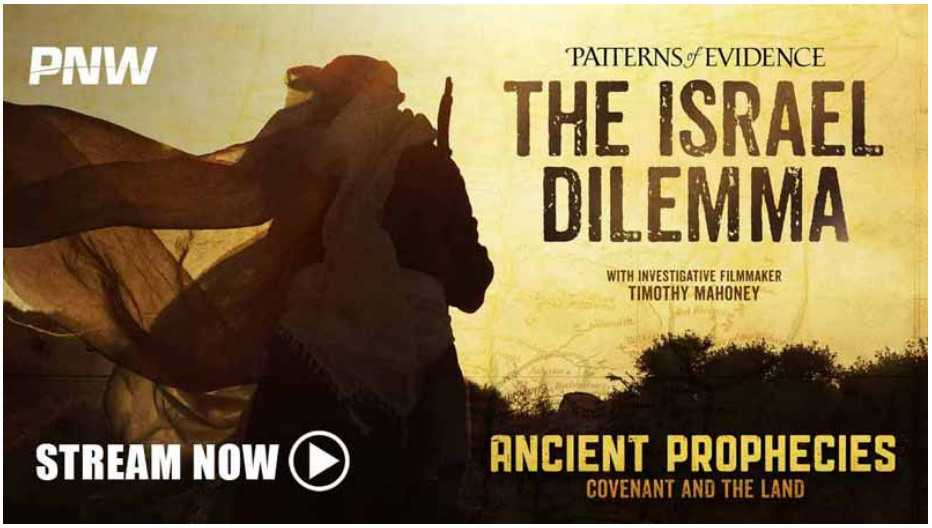
It is like discovering that millions of buildings were constructed using the same defective lock.

The manufacturer can develop a replacement, but every building owner must install it. Some respond immediately. Others take days or weeks. Some never make the necessary repairs.

Meanwhile, attackers begin searching for every building that remains vulnerable.

Not every PHP-powered website is necessarily exposed to the same degree, and security protections can reduce the danger. But the crisis demonstrates how a single underlying software weakness can become an international security emergency.

And the situation becomes considerably more troubling when artificial intelligence enters the picture.



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Artificial Intelligence Is Changing The Rules

For decades, discovering sophisticated software vulnerabilities required considerable technical expertise. Skilled hackers needed to understand programming languages, operating systems, networks, and security defenses.

Artificial intelligence is beginning to change that equation.

AI-powered tools can analyze enormous quantities of computer code, identify suspicious weaknesses, generate potential exploits, and help automate the process of testing systems for vulnerabilities.

In fact, AI-assisted research helped uncover the latest PHP vulnerabilities, demonstrating just how powerful these tools have become.

Imagine thousands of automated hacking agents simultaneously examining websites around the world. They can test different approaches, analyze failures, modify their strategies, and continue operating around the clock.

An attacker who previously had the resources to target a handful of organizations might eventually be capable of investigating thousands.

Defenders are using artificial intelligence as well, but the growing capabilities of both sides are creating a technological arms race with consequences that extend far beyond the cybersecurity industry.

What happens when hackers can discover weaknesses faster than organizations can repair them?

What happens when malicious software becomes capable of coordinating increasingly complex attacks with minimal human involvement?

And what happens when the targets are no longer merely websites, but the financial and physical infrastructure upon which entire nations depend?

When Digital Attacks Become Real-World Disasters

Our modern economy has become extraordinarily dependent upon interconnected computer systems.

Money moves electronically. Businesses maintain digital inventories. Hospitals depend on networked medical systems. Electrical utilities use computerized controls. Shipping companies coordinate deliveries through complex software platforms.

Even purchasing groceries increasingly requires multiple digital systems to function correctly.

A sufficiently widespread cyberattack could therefore create consequences far beyond stolen passwords or inaccessible websites.

Imagine a coordinated attack disrupting major payment processors. Retailers suddenly cannot accept electronic transactions. Customers find their debit cards useless, even though their bank accounts still contain money.

Banks temporarily restrict online access while investigating suspicious activity. Financial institutions begin limiting certain transfers to prevent fraud.

Businesses struggle to pay suppliers, and customers rush to withdraw cash.

Now add attacks against transportation systems, telecommunications providers, or electrical infrastructure.

The disruption could spread rapidly.

We have already witnessed how ransomware attacks against individual hospitals, businesses, and infrastructure operators can interrupt essential services. The greater danger is what could happen if numerous critical systems were compromised simultaneously.

Such a crisis would not necessarily require hackers to steal everyone's money. Simply preventing people from accessing or transferring their funds could produce widespread economic panic.

For a society accustomed to instant digital payments, even several days of serious disruption could feel catastrophic.

And that brings us to perhaps the most consequential question of all.

What kind of solution would governments offer to prevent it from happening again?

The Solution That Could Change Everything

History demonstrates that major crises often accelerate changes that would otherwise take years to implement.

Following a devastating series of cyberattacks, governments and financial institutions would face enormous pressure to restore confidence in the financial system.

The public would demand action. Banks would demand stronger protections. Businesses would insist upon more reliable methods of verifying transactions.

And increasingly, the proposed answer could involve stronger forms of digital identification and centralized financial oversight.

Imagine a future in which every financial transaction requires a government-recognized digital identity. Biometric verification, perhaps using fingerprints, facial recognition, or other unique identifiers, could become standard.

Financial institutions might require approved digital wallets connected to verified personal identities. Advanced artificial intelligence could monitor transactions continuously, identifying suspicious activity and automatically restricting accounts considered dangerous.

Such technologies could offer genuine security benefits. Criminals would find it harder to impersonate account holders, steal identities, or transfer money anonymously.

But there is another side to that equation.

The same infrastructure designed to prevent criminals from accessing your money could potentially prevent you from accessing it as well.

And that raises a question far more important than how sophisticated the technology becomes: Who ultimately decides what constitutes a threat?

Today, that might mean identifying hackers, terrorists, and financial criminals. Tomorrow, could the definition expand to include political dissidents, religious organizations, or individuals who refuse government mandates?

Imagine a financial system in which an algorithm can freeze your accounts because your behavior has been flagged as suspicious. Imagine being denied access to essential services because your digital identity has been suspended or your activities violate government-approved standards.

And imagine having no practical alternative because nearly every bank, payment processor, and major business operates within the same interconnected system.

What begins as protection against criminals could eventually become an instrument for enforcing obedience.

The technology that promises to protect everyone could become the technology that controls everyone.

And after enough devastating cyberattacks, millions of frightened people might welcome such a system.

They might even demand it.

Revelation 13 And The Coming Control Of Buying And Selling

For Christians who study Bible prophecy, these developments bring to mind one of Scripture's most sobering warnings.

Revelation 13:16–17 describes a future system under the authority of the Antichrist:

"And he causeth all, both small and great, rich and poor, free and bond, to receive a mark in their right hand, or in their foreheads: And that no man might buy or sell, save he that had the mark, or the name of the beast, or the number of his name."

Consider the extraordinary implications of those words.

Nearly two thousand years ago, the Apostle John described a future system in which economic participation would be restricted according to an individual's allegiance to a global ruler.

For much of history, the practical enforcement of such a system would have been extraordinarily difficult.

How could authorities prevent someone from purchasing bread from a neighbor? How could they monitor transactions across entire nations? How could they enforce financial restrictions against millions of people simultaneously?

Today, the technological possibilities are becoming much easier to imagine.

Digital currencies, biometric identification, artificial intelligence, automated surveillance, and interconnected financial networks could provide mechanisms for controlling economic participation on an unprecedented scale.

Scripture does not tell us that a cyberattack will introduce the mark of the beast. Nor does it identify a particular digital currency, biometric system, or technological platform as the mark itself.

But it does describe a future in which the ability to buy and sell becomes conditional upon submission to the Antichrist's authority.

The technology capable of enforcing such restrictions is no longer difficult to envision.

What remains to be understood is how the world could become willing to accept it.

A prolonged crisis of confidence in the global financial system could provide part of that answer.

When Security Becomes More Important Than Freedom

Perhaps the most disturbing possibility is that a future system of financial control will not initially be presented as an instrument of oppression.

It may be introduced as the ultimate solution to identity theft, financial fraud, cyberterrorism, and the increasingly dangerous vulnerabilities of our digital economy.

The sales pitch could be remarkably appealing: no more stolen passwords, no more fraudulent transfers, no more anonymous hackers draining accounts, and no more devastating attacks against financial institutions.

All that would be required is participation in a secure, universally recognized system of digital identification and financial authorization.

After experiencing repeated economic disruptions, how many people would object?

How many would willingly surrender a measure of financial independence if they believed doing so would protect their savings, their businesses, and their families?

And how many would eventually regard those who refused to participate as threats to everyone else's security?

That is where the prophetic implications become especially sobering.

The world described in Revelation 13 is not merely technologically advanced. It is a world in which economic survival becomes a powerful instrument of coercion.

The decision to participate is no longer simply about convenience or protection. It becomes a matter of worship, allegiance, and obedience.

Today's cyberattacks are not the fulfillment of that prophecy. But they offer a revealing glimpse of how technological vulnerability, public fear, and the demand for security could help prepare the way for extraordinary systems of control.

The next major cyberattack may be stopped. The next vulnerability may be patched. But with artificial intelligence accelerating the digital arms race, the battle to secure the internet is only beginning.

And the stakes extend far beyond stolen passwords, compromised websites, or temporary banking outages. The real question is who will ultimately control the digital infrastructure upon which modern civilization depends.

Will the future internet remain a place where individuals can communicate, conduct business, and access their money freely? Or will repeated crises lead to a system in which every transaction, every identity, and every financial decision requires approval from an increasingly centralized authority?

Revelation 13 warns that a day is coming when the ability to buy and sell will be tied to allegiance to the Antichrist. The technological foundations for such control are becoming easier to imagine, and the crises that could persuade the world to accept it are becoming increasingly real.

The greatest danger may not be that hackers eventually bring our financial systems to their knees. It may be that a frightened world willingly hands over control of those systems to someone promising that it will never happen again.

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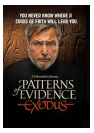
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